Statement

Sensitive

Statement in the matter of R v Vida REID

Name	Leah Norman
Occupation	Purchasing Officer
Address	Known to National Disability Insurance Scheme (NDIS)
Date	11 October 2022

STATES:

1. This statement made by me accurately sets out the evidence that I would be prepared, if necessary, to give in court as a witness.

2. My full name is Leah Norman and I am 43 years of age.

3. My residential address is known to the National Disability Insurance Scheme.

4. I first met Vida Reid when I was working at APM which is an employment services company located in Armadale Western Australia. This would have been in about July 2019 and my position with APM was employment consultant. Vida was employed at another branch office of APM located at Ascott and then transferred over to Armadale.

5. We worked together for while before Vida transferred to another division of APM to be a Local Area Coordinator (LAC) working with NDIS Participants. I didn't have much contact with her and was informed that Vida had left APM and started her own business.

6. As I was looking for a new position, I initiated contact with Vida and met her for a coffee. Over coffee she told me about the business she had started called Forward Focus Group (FFG) and that they were assisting Participants to get signed up with FFG and commence being provided support coordination services.

Signature

Witness

7. At this stage she had two employees who were Chloe and Kaitlyn Osborne who are sisters. Vida offered me position as a Support Coordinator with FFG. I commenced work with them on 14 December 2020 after completing my two weeks' notice period with APM.

8. As a support coordinator, my role was to sit with new Participants, look at the NDIS plan that had been developed for them, explain each line item that had been given, and then link them with the appropriate services. After we had this initial meeting, I would have ongoing contact with the Participants and their service providers. The ultimate goal of support coordination is to have them being able to coordinate their own supports. This was charged under the line item called capacity building. Vida encouraged all us to record excessive hours for this line item.

9. I didn't know very much about the NDIS when I commenced with FFG and was learning as we went along and relied heavily on Vida's knowledge as to how it all worked due to her previous experience.

10. I was responsible for a number of Participants which would have started at about six but grew to about thirty-eight as the business expanded. We were required to track the amount of time we spent with each Participant so Vida could then raise payment requests for those hours. We initially tracked our hours through a software program, but I cannot remember the name of that software. We later swapped over to a program that was specific to the NDIS, but I can't recall the name of hat program either.

11. Participants would come to us with an amount of funding allocated for support coordination services. Vida would encourage us to record hours more than the time that was actually required. This was constant; she would call us dumb and tell us we were putting our jobs in jeopardy by not doing what were told regarding the hours, and that we didn't understand how the NDIS worked.

12. She would tell us all to record hours more than what we actually provided. By us, I mean myself, Chloe, and Kaitlyn. As new employees started with FFG, they were also encouraged to record more hours than they actually delivered for support coordination.



Signature



Witness

13. I understood from the start that I was employed on paper as Vida's support worker under her NDIS plan and was being paid through funding allocated to her plan for this support. I never provided her any physical support but rather always provided support coordination services to various Participants.

14. Pretty much straight away, we started getting complaints from various Participants that they were being overcharged for various supports. These supports were varied and essentially, she billed any line item she could get to. There were line items she couldn't get to as FFG wasn't a registered Provider.

15. With those plans she couldn't get full access to; she would take those Participants back to the NDIS and have those line items unlocked so that an unregistered Provider such as FFG, could then provide those services. I recall that she did this with a Participant named Seyed Yunis Hashimi and her own son, Alexander Reid.

16. Another thing Vida would do was what I called 'invoice bombing.' By this I mean that if a Participant's plan was coming to an end date, she would access their plan through the portal, see how much funding remained and then submit invoices through the Plan Management Agency (PMA) responsible for those Participants for those remaining funds.

17. I know she did this invoice bombing because we started getting complaints from the PMAs. The PMAs had checked with Participants and discovered that they had not received the supports that the PMAs had been invoiced for. Also, as the PMAs knew our business, they also believed that services had not been provided by FFG for invoices that they had received. I recall I received complaints from Provider Choice, Assist Plan Managers and myintegra who are all PMAs.

18. In the time I worked there, the only services that FFG provided were support coordination which includes capacity building, recovery coaching and towards the end of my employment they were providing support workers. Vida registered a company called The Hive so we could separate the support coordination and support workers. I was a partner with Vida in The Hive: she had a 60% controlling interest in The Hive and I had a 40% interest. My husband Steven Norman was listed as the Director of The Hive.

19. If a Participant came through to FFG and they were registered with a PMA that Vida had already had issues with, she would move those Participants over to a PMA that were more compliant, easier to deal with and wouldn't question any of her invoices.

20. In total, I was with FFG for about twelve months; my employment contract lists my start date as 14 December 2020 and I finished with FFG and The Hive in the beginning of October 2021. I left for a number of reasons, but the final straw was when Vida had a facelift.

21. She told the NDIS that she had a fall due to her Multiple Sclerosis had injured her face which required 150 stitches. Vida then charged her plan for hotel accommodation to recover and also a nurse who stayed with her at the hotel during this recovery process. She also demanded an emergency review of her plan.

This statement is true to the best of my knowledge and belief. I have made this statement knowing that, if it is tendered in evidence, I will be guilty of a crime if I have wilfully included in the statement anything that I know to be false or that I do not believe is true.

Signature L Norman
Leah Norman

Statement taken and signature witnessed by me about 7.40pm on 11 October 2022 at Baldivis in Western Australia.

Signature

Gerard Righetti
Assistant Director Fraud Investigations

Perth, Western Australia

Signature

Witness